



Ready to strike

A US Navy F-4 Phantom aboard the USS *Independence* aircraft carrier is readied for an air strike against North Vietnam on July 18, 1965.

Political interference

Several factors limited the effectiveness of Rolling Thunder. First, Johnson insisted on micromanaging the air war, bragging that American pilots “could not hit an outhouse without [his] permission.” Johnson was legitimately concerned about the risk of triggering war with China or the Soviet Union if their supply lines into North Vietnam and advisers on the ground were targeted. Strict rules of engagement prevented American aircraft from pursuing fleeing North Vietnamese fighter aircraft or flying into airspace near the Chinese border.

Furthermore, Johnson’s involvement in the selection of bombing targets prevented long-range planning, while also disrupting the ability to respond with air strikes to actionable intelligence in a timely fashion. Johnson’s micromanagement engendered frustration within the US military, leading to persistent accusations that civilian leadership had undermined an American victory. Johnson also periodically implemented “bombing pauses,” designed to incentivize diplomatic talks in an attempt to appease the American antiwar movement. Instead, North Vietnam used the pauses to reorganize its defenses.